Deep Research Report

Direct Instruction versus Inclusion: What the Latest Research Says About Special Education Student Performance

Prepared: 2026-05-15

Source categories covered: Government & Official, News & Journalism, Academic & Peer-Reviewed, Industry / Practitioner / Nonprofit (all four returned valid results)

Total sources analyzed: 49 | High reliability: 22 | Medium: 12 | Low: 15

Major claims cross-referenced: 10 | Contradictions flagged: 4 | Single-source claims: 6

● **High** ● **Medium** ● **Low**

Confidence indicator used throughout Section 2

Executive Summary

The phrase "Direct Instruction versus Inclusion" sets up a contest between two things that are not opposites and not even the same kind of thing. Direct Instruction is a way of teaching. Inclusion is a place where teaching happens. A student with a disability can receive rigorous Direct Instruction inside a fully inclusive general-education classroom, or receive vague, unstructured teaching in a self-contained room. Read carefully, the research says the pedagogy question has a clear answer and the placement question does not.

Bottom-line assessment:

- Explicit, systematic, teacher-directed instruction, the method at the core of Direct Instruction, has one of the strongest and most durable evidence bases in education for students with disabilities. A meta-analysis of 328 studies spanning 1966 to 2016, decades of learning-disability intervention research with mean effect sizes near 0.79, cognitive-load theory, and the federal What Works Clearinghouse practice guides all point the same direction.
- Inclusion as a placement produces, at best, a small academic benefit (about d = 0.35) and frequently a null effect, and even that estimate is compromised by selection bias. A Campbell Collaboration systematic review found only 15 of roughly 2,000 studies rigorous enough to count, and a leading special-education scholar calls the inclusion evidence base "fundamentally flawed." Inclusion does not appear to harm typically developing peers.
- The strongest consensus across all four source categories is that instructional quality and intensity, not setting, drive outcomes. Inclusion is the legal default under the IDEA least-restrictive-environment mandate, 67 percent of students with disabilities already spend most of the day in general education, and it is a defensible civil-rights position. But placement by itself is not a treatment.
- The achievement gap is severe and not closing. On the 2024 NAEP, about 72 percent of fourth graders with disabilities scored below basic, the lowest category.

One apparent contradiction should not mislead the reader. The What Works Clearinghouse rated the branded curricula "Direct Instruction" and "Reading Mastery" as having "no discernible effects" for special education students. Those verdicts each rest on a single qualifying study, are up to 19 years old, and in the Reading Mastery case compared one Direct Instruction program against another Direct Instruction program. They do not overturn the broader explicit-instruction evidence base, and Section 3 treats this in detail.

Coverage note: all four research agents returned valid, well-sourced results. No source category failed or had thin coverage. Tennessee-specific figures were added in a follow-up data pass and appear in the Tennessee Data Appendix; one narrow residual gap is noted there.

1. Background and Context

Two terms that are routinely confused

Direct Instruction with capital letters refers to a specific family of curricula designed by Siegfried Engelmann beginning in the 1960s, originally branded DISTAR. These programs, including Reading Mastery, Corrective Reading, and Connecting Math Concepts (now published by McGraw Hill), are tightly scripted, mastery-based, fast-paced, and built on extensive field testing. The teacher follows a prescribed sequence, students respond frequently, and each skill is taught to mastery before the next is introduced.

Lowercase "direct" or "explicit" instruction is the broader instructional principle underneath the branded programs: clear modeling by the teacher, guided practice, immediate corrective feedback, and cumulative review, often summarized as "I do, we do, you do." Most of the strongest research evidence concerns this broader principle, which can be delivered without a scripted product.

Inclusion is not a teaching method at all. It is a placement model: educating students with disabilities in general-education classrooms alongside non-disabled peers, with supplementary aids and services. It is anchored in the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA) least-restrictive-environment mandate. Co-teaching, in which a general educator and a special educator share a classroom, is the most common delivery model. Inclusion is contrasted with more restrictive settings: resource rooms (part-time pull-out) and self-contained special-education classes, where intensive, often Direct Instruction-based teaching has traditionally been delivered.

Why the topic matters now

In school year 2022-23, 7.5 million students ages 3 to 21 received IDEA services, equal to 15 percent of all public-school students, up from 6.4 million (13 percent) a decade earlier. Specific learning disabilities are the single largest category at 32 percent. National reading and math scores have declined, the science-of-reading movement has reshaped reading-instruction policy in more than two dozen states, and federal special-education governance is in flux. Against that backdrop, district leaders increasingly ask whether students with disabilities are better served by placement in the general-education classroom or by intensive specialized instruction. This report shows why that framing is the wrong question, and what the right one is.

2. Key Findings

Findings are organized by theme and weave together government, news, academic, and industry evidence. Each finding carries a confidence indicator.

2.1 The question contains two different questions

All four research agents independently flagged the same issue: "Direct Instruction versus Inclusion" conflates a pedagogy question (how to teach) with a placement question (where to

teach). The academic literature treats them as separate variables, and the strongest causal evidence is about the how. The two are not mutually exclusive: explicit instruction can be, and increasingly is, delivered inside inclusive classrooms. Keeping the two ideas distinct is the single most important move for interpreting the evidence below. ***[High confidence]***

2.2 Direct Instruction as a pedagogy: strong, durable evidence

The Stockard et al. (2018) meta-analysis in the Review of Educational Research examined half a century of research, 1966 to 2016, across 328 studies, 413 study designs, and nearly 4,000 effect estimates. All estimated effects were positive and statistically significant except some affective metaregressions. Effects were moderate to large, comparable in magnitude to the gap between advantaged and disadvantaged students, showed little decline during maintenance, and grew with more program exposure. ***[High confidence]***

Project Follow Through, the largest education experiment ever conducted (1968-1977, 22 instructional models, roughly 200,000 children, 178 communities), found Direct Instruction was the only model with consistently positive effects across basic skills, cognitive-conceptual skills, and affective measures such as self-esteem. Models explicitly designed to build cognitive skills or self-esteem often produced negative effects on those very outcomes. ***[Medium confidence]***

Decades of intervention research on students with learning disabilities converge on the same point. Swanson and Hoskyn (1998) found a mean effect size of 0.79 across experimental intervention studies, with a combined direct-instruction and strategy-instruction model outperforming competitors. Gersten et al. (2009) found explicit math-instruction components producing effects from 0.21 to 1.56. Recent reading-intervention syntheses (2020-2023) confirm that effective interventions are systematic and explicit, with moderate average effects around g = 0.37. Cognitive-load theory (Kirschner, Sweller, and Clark, 2006) explains why: novices, which describes most students with disabilities in new content, have limited working memory and learn far more efficiently when explicitly shown what to do. ***[High confidence]***

Federal guidance endorses the method. The What Works Clearinghouse practice guides assign "strong" evidence ratings to explicit and systematic instruction for struggling math students (2021, based on six randomized trials) and to decoding, fluency, and comprehension instruction for struggling readers in grades 4 to 9 (2022). The federally funded National Center on Intensive Intervention builds its reading, math, and behavior resources on explicit-instruction principles, and the Council for Exceptional Children lists explicit instruction among the 22 High-Leverage Practices every special educator should master. ***[High confidence]***

2.3 Inclusion as a placement: weak and mixed academic evidence

The most rigorous recent meta-analysis (Kramer, Moller, and Zimmermann, 2021, Review of Educational Research; 40 studies, roughly 11,987 students) found that students with general learning difficulties scored modestly better academically in inclusive than in segregated settings, d = 0.35 (small to medium), but inclusion had no effect on self-concept or well-being, d = 0.00. Critically, cross-sectional studies showed larger gains than longitudinal ones, a signature of

selection bias: higher-performing students with disabilities are preferentially placed in inclusion. ***[High confidence]***

The Campbell Collaboration systematic review (Dalgaard et al., 2022) screened roughly 2,000 studies and found only 15 met methodological-quality standards. Across those 15, inclusion showed no consistent academic or psychosocial effect in either direction. The thinness of the evidence base is itself the headline finding. Building on this, Vanderbilt scholar Douglas Fuchs and colleagues argue the inclusion evidence is "fundamentally flawed" because studies fail to control for pre-diagnosis achievement and disability severity; when those confounds are equated, the inclusion advantage disappears. ***[High confidence]***

Inclusion does not appear to harm typically developing peers. Kramer et al. found non-significant effects on peers without learning difficulties for both academic (d = -0.14) and psychosocial (d = 0.06) outcomes. This is one of the more settled points in the literature and is corroborated by news and advocacy sources. ***[Medium confidence]***

2.4 Co-teaching and combined-service models

Co-teaching outcomes depend entirely on the comparison group. King-Sears et al. (2021) found co-taught students with disabilities outperformed those in self-contained settings (g = 0.47, moderate) but showed no significant advantage over a solo-taught general-education class. Implementation fidelity is poorly documented, and special educators often function as classroom aides rather than equal partners. An ASCD practitioner review reported that inclusion-only delivery produced the weakest reading gains for students with learning disabilities, while a combined model of general-education instruction plus periodic resource-room support outperformed both inclusion-only and pull-out-only approaches. ***[Medium confidence]***

2.5 The reconciling consensus: instruction beats setting

This is the strongest area of agreement across all four source categories. Outcomes for students with disabilities are driven by the intensity and quality of instruction, not by the room they sit in. A well-implemented inclusive classroom that delivers explicit instruction outperforms a poorly run one; intensive specialized instruction outperforms an overwhelmed general-education teacher. The federal apparatus does not pit Direct Instruction against inclusion: it positions explicit instruction as what intensifies support in any setting. As the U.S. Department of Education's special-education research commissioner put it, valuing inclusion and valuing the academic support students need are not at cross purposes. ***[High confidence]***

2.6 The achievement gap and the policy moment

Whatever the current mix of pedagogy and placement, students with disabilities remain concentrated among the lowest performers. On the 2024 NAEP, about 72 percent of fourth graders with disabilities scored below basic, and roughly one-third of the nation's lowest-performing quartile has a disability. Meanwhile the science-of-reading movement, catalyzed by the APM Reports podcast "Sold a Story," has produced reading-instruction laws in at least 26

states since 2022, many mandating the explicit, systematic phonics instruction that structured-literacy advocates consider the standard of care for students with dyslexia. Federal special-education governance is simultaneously contracting, raising questions about whether general-education teachers will have the training and resources inclusion requires. ***[Medium confidence]***

3. Points of Contradiction

3.1 What Works Clearinghouse branded reviews vs. the Direct Instruction meta-analysis

The sharpest contradiction in the evidence. The What Works Clearinghouse rated the branded "Direct Instruction" program (2007) as having no discernible effects on the oral language, print knowledge, cognition, or math of special-education students, and rated "Reading Mastery" (2012) as having no discernible effects for students with learning disabilities. Against this, the Stockard et al. meta-analysis of 328 studies reports uniformly positive, moderate-to-large effects.

Assessment: the contradiction is more apparent than real. The WWC verdicts each rest on exactly one study that met its strict design standards (the Reading Mastery review used a 30-student study), the WWC reviews are 14 to 19 years old, and the single Reading Mastery study compared Reading Mastery against Horizons Fast Track, which is itself a Direct Instruction program. "No discernible difference" between two DI programs is not evidence that DI fails against a non-DI alternative. The National Institute for Direct Instruction has formally disputed the WWC methodology. The broader explicit-instruction evidence base, including the WWC's own 2021 and 2022 practice guides, strongly favors the method. The Stockard synthesis carries the stronger evidentiary weight, with the caveat that one of its authors has long-standing ties to the DI advocacy community.

3.2 A small positive inclusion effect vs. a null effect

Kramer et al. (2021) found a small-to-medium academic benefit of inclusion ($d = 0.35$); the Campbell review (2022) found no consistent effect. Assessment: the two are partially reconcilable. Kramer focused specifically on students with general learning difficulties, while the Campbell review covered special educational needs broadly and applied stricter study-quality screens. Kramer's own authors flag that selection bias inflates the cross-sectional estimates. The honest reading is that inclusion's academic effect is somewhere between null and small, and is not well established.

3.3 Advocacy vs. research on inclusion for students with the most significant needs

TASH and the full-inclusion advocacy community hold that all students benefit from general-education placement "regardless of the severity of disability." The Fuchs critique and the Campbell review hold that the evidence cannot support firm placement claims in either

direction. Assessment: the research position has the stronger evidentiary footing. The advocacy claim frames correlational findings (time in general education correlates with better outcomes) in causal language and outruns what placement-comparison research can establish. That said, the advocacy position rests partly on a civil-rights argument, that inclusion is a right rather than an intervention, which is a values claim that evidence neither confirms nor refutes.

3.4 Trade-press optimism vs. research caution

Education Week and similar outlets routinely present inclusive classrooms as benefiting every student. Assessment: these pieces are typically Q&A or opinion formats relying on practitioner anecdote rather than empirical data. They are not wrong about inclusion's social and civil-rights value, but they overstate the academic evidence, which is mixed at best.

4. Single-Source Claims

Claims supported by only one source category, flagged for extra scrutiny.

NIFDI effect sizes for special education

The National Institute for Direct Instruction cites an Adams and Engelmann meta-analysis of 34 studies with a mean effect size of 0.97 overall and 0.90 for special-education students. Only the industry/advocacy category reports these specific figures, and NIFDI exists to promote DI. The direction is corroborated by the independent Stockard meta-analysis, but the precise magnitudes should be treated as advocacy figures until independently verified.

McGraw Hill district results

McGraw Hill reports that Macomb ISD in Michigan raised third-grade reading proficiency from 77 percent (2021) to 86 percent (2024) using Reading Mastery Transformations. This is a curriculum publisher's marketing case study, not a controlled comparison, and carries clear commercial interest.

Hattie effect-size rankings

John Hattie's syntheses place Direct Instruction at d = 0.59 to 0.60, well above his 0.40 "year's growth" benchmark. Only the academic category cites this, and Hattie's method of averaging heterogeneous meta-analyses has drawn substantive criticism. Treat the numbers as directional, not exact.

ASCD combined-services percentile data

An ASCD review (drawing on Marston) reports a combined-services group improving from the 15th to the 20th percentile and posting higher spring oral-reading scores than inclusion-only or pull-out-only groups. Only the industry category surfaces this, the underlying study is older, and the gains are modest.

CRPE "stopgap" framing

The Center on Reinventing Public Education argues special education has become an exclusionary stopgap for a general-education system designed for uniformity rather than difference. This appears only in news coverage of a single think-tank position paper; it is a policy argument, not an empirical finding.

Tennessee "Say Dyslexia" implementation confusion

Reporting that Tennessee's 2016 Say Dyslexia law still confuses parents and educators a decade later comes from a single regional outlet (Nashville Scene) and relies on qualitative interviews rather than outcome data. Plausible and locally relevant, but uncorroborated.

5. Practical Implications

For a district decision-maker, the evidence supports the following, ordered by confidence.

Higher-confidence actions

- ● Stop framing the choice as Direct Instruction versus inclusion. Frame it as: every student with a disability receives explicit, systematic, intensive instruction, delivered in the least restrictive setting that can actually sustain that intensity.
- ● Invest in explicit-instruction capacity for general-education teachers. Inclusion only works academically when the inclusive classroom delivers the structured instruction that students with disabilities need. Structured literacy and the High-Leverage Practices framework are concrete training targets.
- ● Treat placement as an individualized IEP-team decision tied to instructional need, not as a blanket policy in either direction. Reserve more intensive settings for students whose required intensity cannot be delivered in general education.

Medium-confidence actions

- ● If co-teaching is used, monitor implementation fidelity. The measured benefit disappears when the special educator functions as an aide rather than a genuine co-teacher.
- ● Measure outcomes, not minutes-in-setting. Inclusion rate (percent of time in general education) is a compliance metric, not an achievement metric. Track subgroup performance directly.
- ● Consider combined-service models for students with learning disabilities, where general-education instruction is paired with targeted resource-room support, rather than defaulting to inclusion-only or pull-out-only.

Open questions

- Longitudinal evidence is thin. Most placement studies are cross-sectional and confounded by selection bias.
- Students with significant cognitive disabilities are under-studied; most of the instructional evidence concerns high-incidence disabilities such as learning disabilities and dyslexia.

- Cost and return-on-investment comparisons of co-teaching, resource, and self-contained models are essentially absent from the literature.

6. Federal and State Policy Context

IDEA and the least-restrictive-environment mandate. Federal regulation (34 CFR 300.114) requires that, to the maximum extent appropriate, children with disabilities are educated with non-disabled children, and that removal to separate settings occur only when the disability is such that education in regular classes with supplementary aids and services cannot be achieved satisfactorily. Inclusion is therefore the legal default; restrictive placement requires IEP-team justification. The Office of Special Education Programs enforces this through Results Driven Accountability.

The national picture. In fall 2022, 67 percent of students with disabilities spent 80 percent or more of the day in general classes, up from 61 percent in 2012; 16 percent spent 40 to 79 percent, 13 percent spent less than 40 percent, and 95 percent attended regular schools. Among students exiting special education in 2021-22, about 74 percent graduated with a standard diploma and 15 percent dropped out, both figures improved over the prior decade.

ESSA and the science of reading. The Every Student Succeeds Act requires reporting of the students-with-disabilities subgroup, keeping their performance visible in accountability systems. Since 2022, at least 26 states have passed reading-instruction laws aligning curricula with cognitive science, and at least 15 have banned the three-cueing method. These laws push general-education reading instruction toward the explicit, systematic approach this report identifies as effective, which is relevant for the large share of students with disabilities identified with reading-related disabilities.

7. Tennessee Data Appendix

Tennessee-specific figures, compiled in a follow-up data pass. Where a clean statewide all-disabilities figure was not publicly retrievable, the closest verified Tennessee data is given and labeled.

Policy framework

- Tennessee's "Say Dyslexia" law (2016) requires screening for characteristics of dyslexia within the response-to-intervention framework. Students who screen positive receive an Individualized Learning Plan for Characteristics of Dyslexia (ILP-D), a support plan rather than a formal disability diagnosis. A decade on, reporting indicates parents and educators still confuse the ILP-D with IEPs and 504 plans.
- The Tennessee Literacy Success Act (2021) mandates phonics-based, foundational-skills reading instruction statewide, aligning Tennessee with the explicit, systematic instruction the research supports.

- A 2023 federal IDEA determination placed Tennessee in the "needs assistance" category for Part B requirements, a signal worth district-level monitoring.

Placement: where Tennessee educates students with disabilities

Tennessee does not publish a single headline statewide inclusion rate in an easily retrievable form, but its State Systemic Improvement Plan (FFY 2021 Part B Annual Performance Report) gives a direct measure for the cohort of districts in its "Access for All" initiative. Among those districts, the share of students with a specific learning disability served in the general-education setting 80 percent or more of the day rose from 73.95 percent (baseline, May 2019) to 84.73 percent (May 2022) after training focused on access to core instruction. Both figures sit at or above the national rate of 67 percent, indicating Tennessee leans inclusive. The precise statewide all-disabilities figure (IDEA Indicator 5A) is published in TDOE's Special Education Data Services reports and the federal Part B data display.

Performance: how Tennessee students with disabilities are doing

On the 2024 NAEP, Tennessee's overall results held steady and ran slightly above the national public average (grade 4 reading 215 vs. 214; grade 4 math 240 vs. 237; grade 8 reading 259 vs. 257; grade 8 math 276 vs. 272). For all Tennessee students, 39 percent of grade 4 readers and 22 percent of grade 4 math students scored below NAEP Basic; at grade 8 the below-basic shares were 32 percent in reading and 38 percent in math. NAEP flagged declines for Tennessee's students-with-disabilities subgroup at grade 8 in both reading and math between 2022 and 2024; at grade 4, the subgroup showed no significant change in reading.

On the state TCAP, 39 percent of all Tennessee students met or exceeded grade-level expectations in English language arts in 2024, and about 40 percent did so in grades 3-8 mathematics. TDOE's public results deck shows the students-with-disabilities subgroup only as a bar chart without an extractable headline number; the chart and TDOE's narrative confirm the subgroup gained 1 to 2 points but that "achievement gaps persist that were present before the pandemic." The most precise verified statewide figure comes from the State Systemic Improvement Plan: in 2021-22, 33.59 percent of students with a specific learning disability in grades 3-8 scored at or above "Approaching" on the statewide ELA assessment, meaning roughly two-thirds scored "Below." Actual proficiency (met or exceeded expectations) for that group sat in the low single digits. Specific learning disability is Tennessee's, and the nation's, largest disability category.

Residual data gap

One figure remains outside this report: the exact 2024 TCAP proficiency rate for the all-disabilities subgroup, as distinct from the specific-learning-disability measure above. It is published only inside TDOE's interactive report-card dashboard and the downloadable assessment data files, which require an interactive portal session to extract. Recommended as a quick follow-up for any Greeneville City Schools or Tennessee-specific analysis.

8. Claim Cross-Reference Matrix

For each major claim: a check mark means the source category supports it, an X means it contradicts, a dash means it did not address it.

Claim	Gov	News	Acad	Indus	Agreement
Direct/explicit instruction produces positive, moderate-to-large academic effects for students with disabilities	✓	✓	✓	✓	Full
The branded "Direct Instruction"/"Reading Mastery" programs show "no discernible effects" (WWC reviews)	✓	—	—	✓	Single category (contested)
Inclusion as a placement produces clear academic benefits for students with disabilities	—	X	X	X/✓	Conflicting
Inclusion does not harm typically developing peers	—	✓	✓	✓	Full (among reporting)
Instructional quality and intensity, not setting, drive outcomes	✓	✓	✓	✓	Full (strongest consensus)
Inclusion is the legal default and is already the dominant placement	✓	✓	—	✓	Full
Co-teaching beats self-contained settings but not solo general education	—	—	✓	✓	Partial (consistent)
Students with disabilities remain concentrated among the lowest academic performers	✓	✓	—	—	Partial (consistent)
Explicit, systematic structured literacy is the standard of care for dyslexia	✓	✓	✓	✓	Full
Direct Instruction is underused despite strong evidence, due to philosophical resistance	—	—	—	✓	Single category (opinion)

9. Source Reliability Matrix

All 49 sources, sorted by aggregate reliability score (highest first). Score = source-type weight (Gov/Academic 1.0, News 0.8, Industry 0.7) x agent confidence (High 1.0, Medium 0.7, Low 0.4) x URL status (Live 1.0, Redirect/Paywalled 0.8, Skipped 0.7, Dead 0.3), plus a corroboration bonus (+0.1 if cited by 2+ agents). Tiers: High at or above 0.80, Medium 0.50 to 0.79, Low below 0.50.

Source	Category	Agent Conf.	URL Status	Score	Tier	Cited By
IDEA Sec. 300.114, LRE Requirements (US Dept. of Education)	Gov	High	Live	1.00	**High**	Gov
NCES Fast Facts: Inclusion of Students with Disabilities (2024)	Gov	High	Live	1.00	**High**	Gov
NCES Condition of Education: Students With Disabilities (2024)	Gov	High	Live	1.00	**High**	Gov
Dalgaard et al. (2022), Campbell systematic review on inclusion	Academic	High	Live (PMC mirror)	1.00	**High**	Academic
WWC Reading Interventions, Grades 4-9 practice guide (2022)	Gov	High	Live	1.00	**High**	Gov
NAEP / Nation's Report Card 2024 (NCES; NAGB takeaways)	Gov	High	Live	1.00	**High**	Gov
TDOE State Systemic Improvement Plan / FFY2021 Part B APR (TN)	Gov	High	Live	1.00	**High**	TN follow-up
TDOE 2024 NAEP Tennessee State Results Overview	Gov	High	Live	1.00	**High**	TN follow-up
TDOE 2024 TCAP State-Level Results Overview	Gov	High	Live	1.00	**High**	TN follow-up
NCES NAEP 2024 Grade 4 Reading State Snapshot, Tennessee	Gov	High	Live	1.00	**High**	TN follow-up
Hechinger Report: special-ed inclusion evidence "flawed" (2025)	News	High	Live	0.90	**High**	News, Academic
Stockard et al. (2018), DI meta-analysis, Rev. of Educ. Research	Academic	High	Redirect (DOI)	0.90	**High**	Academic, Industry
Hechinger Report: readers react to inclusion column (2025)	News	High	Live	0.80	**High**	News
APM Reports: "Sold a Story" podcast/series (2022-2025)	News	High	Live	0.80	**High**	News
APM Reports: new reading laws sweep the nation (2025)	News	High	Live	0.80	**High**	News
WWC Direct Instruction intervention report (2007)	Gov	Medium	Live	0.80	**High**	Gov, Industry
WWC Assisting Students Struggling with Mathematics guide (2021)	Gov	High	Skipped (PDF)	0.70	**Medium**	Gov
Kirschner, Sweller & Clark (2006), minimal guidance	Academic	High	Paywalled	0.80	**High**	Academic
Kramer, Moller & Zimmermann (2021), inclusion meta-analysis	Academic	High	Redirect (DOI)	0.80	**High**	Academic
Swanson & Hoskyn (1998), LD intervention meta-analysis	Academic	High	Redirect (DOI)	0.80	**High**	Academic
Gersten et al. (2009), math instruction meta-analysis	Academic	High	Redirect (DOI)	0.80	**High**	Academic
Hall et al. (2023), 40 years of dyslexia reading intervention	Academic	High	Paywalled	0.80	**High**	Academic
National Center on Intensive Intervention / OSEP (AIR)	Gov	High	Blocked, likely valid	0.80	**High**	Gov
IDEA 43rd Annual Report to Congress (2023)	Gov	High	Skipped	0.70	**Medium**	Gov
"Just How Effective is Direct Instruction?" (Mason & Otero, PMC)	Academic	Medium	Live	0.70	**Medium**	Academic
Foundational-skills reading interventions meta-analysis (PMC)	Academic	High	Skipped	0.70	**Medium**	Academic
Hattie, Visible Learning effect-size rankings	Academic	Medium	Live	0.70	**Medium**	Academic
IRIS Center (Vanderbilt), High-Leverage	Industry	High	Live	0.70	**Medium**	Industry

Practices						
Council for Exceptional Children, Specially Designed Instruction	Industry	High	Live	0.70	**Medium**	Industry
King-Sears et al. (2021), co-teaching meta-analysis	Academic	Medium	Paywalled	0.66	**Medium**	Academic, Industry
NIFDI, Project Follow Through summary	Industry	Medium	Live	0.59	**Medium**	Academic, Industry
Nashville Scene: "Say Dyslexia" a decade on (2026)	News	Medium	Live	0.56	**Medium**	News
K-12 Dive: a potential "fix" for special education (CRPE, 2025)	News	Medium	Live	0.56	**Medium**	News
Chalkbeat NY: students need more explicit instruction (2025)	News	Medium	Live	0.56	**Medium**	News
Wing Institute: DI meta-analysis summary	Industry	Medium	Live	0.49	**Low**	Industry
ASCD: Inclusion and Students with Learning Disabilities (2001)	Industry	Medium	Live	0.49	**Low**	Industry
EdWeek: why inclusive classrooms benefit every student (2026)	News	Medium	Paywalled	0.45	**Low**	News
EdWeek: parents should continue filing complaints (2025)	News	Medium	Paywalled	0.45	**Low**	News
EdWeek: Spotlight on Science of Reading for SWD	News	Medium	Paywalled	0.45	**Low**	News
K-12 Dive: advocates form united front to protect IDEA (2025)	News	Medium	Skipped	0.39	**Low**	News
Education Next: "Has Inclusion Gone Too Far?" (2018)	News	Medium	Skipped	0.39	**Low**	News
The Reading League, Science of Reading Defining Guide	Industry	Medium	Skipped	0.34	**Low**	Industry
International Dyslexia Association, Structured Literacy	Industry	Medium	Skipped	0.34	**Low**	Industry
Education Next: meta-analysis confirms DI effectiveness	Industry	Low	Live	0.28	**Low**	Industry
NIFDI: Special Education and Direct Instruction (JoDI, 2005)	Industry	Low	Live	0.28	**Low**	Industry
TASH, Position Statement on Inclusive Education	Industry	Low	Live	0.28	**Low**	Industry
Fordham Institute: DI, "Rodney Dangerfield of curriculum"	Industry	Low	Skipped	0.20	**Low**	Industry
McGraw Hill: Direct Instruction Research & Success	Industry	Low	Skipped	0.20	**Low**	Industry
WWC Reading Mastery intervention report (2012)	Gov	Medium	Skipped (PDF)	0.49	**Low**	Gov

Summary statistics: 49 sources total, 22 high reliability, 12 medium, 15 low. URL verification: 30 URLs checked; 0 dead; 1 paywalled source (the Campbell systematic review) replaced with its open-access PubMed Central mirror; 3 publisher DOI links (SAGE) returned platform redirects and were retained as likely valid; 6 sources were paywalled or access-blocked and retained. The 4 Tennessee sources were added in a follow-up data pass and confirmed live. Sources not individually verified were scored with a skipped-status penalty.

10. References

Sorted alphabetically. Reliability tier in brackets.

APM Reports (2022-2025). Sold a Story: How Teaching Kids to Read Went So Wrong. https://features.apmreports.org/sold-a-story/ [High]

APM Reports (2025). New reading laws sweep the nation following Sold a Story. https://www.apmreports.org/story/2025/10/16/legislators-reading-laws-sold-a-story [High]

ASCD / Holloway, J. (2001). Inclusion and Students with Learning Disabilities. Educational Leadership. https://www.ascd.org/el/articles/-inclusion-and-students-with-learning-disabilities [Low]

Barshay, J. / Hechinger Report (2025). A researcher said the evidence on special education inclusion is flawed. Readers weighed in. https://hechingerreport.org/proof-points-readers-react-special-education-inclusion/ [High]

Barshay, J. / Hechinger Report (2025). Top scholar says evidence for special education inclusion is 'fundamentally flawed.' https://hechingerreport.org/proof-points-special-education-inclusion-research-flawed/ [High]

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Methodology note: This report synthesizes the independent findings of four parallel research agents (Government, News, Academic, and Industry source categories). Claims were cross-referenced, URLs verified where accessible, and each source assigned an aggregate reliability score. A Tier 1 internal consistency check was applied to every numeric figure and citation. All four source categories returned valid results.